TEACHING NOTES | PRIMARY EDUCATION | INDUCTION PROGRAMME

Teaching Methods for Primary Classes

How young children learn best - and the methods that work in a real primary classroom

Practical notes for primary school teachers: storytelling, play-based learning, questioning, demonstration, pair and group work, early reading, early maths, multigrade teaching, and checking understanding - explained in simple language with classroom examples you can use the next morning.

Inside this note set

The 12 core methods for Classes 1-5 • How primary children think and learn • Early literacy and numeracy methods • Multigrade and large-class teaching • A complete model lesson • One-page checklist for daily use and induction revision

For the classroom

Every method comes with steps, an example and a common mistake to avoid.

For induction

Covers the pedagogy and educational psychology themes taught in the Induction Programme books.

For low resources

All activities use the board, textbooks, stones, sticks, bottle caps and children's own experience.

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Government Primary School Koz Kalay, Buner | Free teaching notes - fahadkz155.github.io/fahad-digital-universe

These notes summarise standard primary pedagogy and induction training themes for teachers' own study and classroom use. Adapt every activity to your class, textbook and local curriculum.

START HERE

Contents and how to use these notes

A teaching method is not good or bad by itself. It is good when it matches three things: the age of the children, the objective of the lesson, and the size and level of your class.

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How to use this set

1. **Before the lesson:** read the method page and copy the steps into your lesson plan.

2. **During the lesson:** follow the steps in order. Do not skip the practice stage - children learn by doing, not only by watching.

3. **After the lesson:** tick the checklist on page 15. Note which children did not understand, and reteach them first tomorrow.

> **One rule for every method:** Talk less, let children do more. In a 35-minute primary lesson, the teacher should speak for about one-third of the time. The rest belongs to children's talk, practice, play and written work.

SECTION 1

First principles: how primary children learn

Methods work when they fit the child's mind. Six facts from child psychology decide which method will succeed.

1. Children aged 5-11 think in concrete things

They understand what they can see, touch and act out. Abstract rules alone do not stick. Start with a real object, picture, story or action, then move to words and symbols.

2. Attention is short and grows with age

A Class 1 child can focus for about 10-15 minutes on one activity; a Class 5 child for about 20-25 minutes. Change the activity - listen, speak, move, write - before attention breaks.

3. Children learn by doing and by imitating

They copy what the teacher and classmates do. Your pronunciation, handwriting and manners are all lessons, whether you plan them or not.

4. Repetition builds memory - but it must vary

New learning needs 5-8 encounters. Repeat through a song, a game, a picture and a written task - not by copying the same line ten times.

5. Feelings come before learning

A frightened or humiliated child does not learn. Praise, safety and a predictable routine are the conditions that make every method work. Correct the work, never shame the child.

6. Language grows through talk

Children learn words by hearing and using them. A silent classroom may look disciplined, but it slows language learning. Plan talk into every lesson: pairs, groups, full-sentence answers.

Teacher-centred or child-centred?

Teacher-centred (use briefly)	Child-centred (use most of the lesson)
Teacher explains, demonstrates, reads aloud. Children listen.	Children practise, discuss, play, make, write and present.
Best for: new concept, safety instructions, modelling.	Best for: practice, language, confidence, deep learning.
Risk if overused: passive, bored children.	Risk if unguided: noise without learning. Set a clear task.

The balance: Start teacher-centred for 5-8 minutes to model the new learning, then move to child-centred activity for the rest of the lesson.

SECTION 2

The method map: 12 methods at a glance

Keep this page open when you plan. Choose one main method per lesson objective - two at most - and use it fully, instead of touching five methods lightly.

Method	Best for	Classes
Storytelling	Listening, vocabulary, values, imagination	1-5
Read-aloud	Reading model, love of books, comprehension	1-5
Play-based learning	Language, number, social skills, motor skills	1-3
Activity-based learning	Concepts in science, maths, social studies	2-5
Questioning	Checking understanding, thinking, discussion	1-5
Demonstration	Skills: handwriting, sums, experiments, craft	1-5
Pair work	Speaking practice, quick checks, reading partners	1-5
Group work	Projects, problem solving, experiments	3-5
Phonics	Early reading in English and Urdu	1-3
Concrete materials (CPA)	Number concepts, place value, fractions	1-5
Role play / drama	Language use, empathy, social situations	2-5
Peer learning	Revision, multigrade classes, slow learners	3-5

Choosing in 30 seconds: Ask three questions. Is it a *skill*? Demonstrate, then practise. Is it a *concept*? Use concrete material or an activity first. Is it *language*? Use story, talk and pair work. Then check: can every child take part, not only the front row?

SECTION 3

Storytelling, read-aloud and picture talk

Before children can read stories, they must hear stories. Listening builds vocabulary, sentence patterns, memory and the desire to read.

Storytelling in 5 steps

1 **Choose:** a short story with a clear beginning, problem and end. Local and animal stories work best for young classes.

2 **Prepare:** learn the story - do not read it from the page. Note 3-4 new words to teach before you begin.

3 **Settle:** children sit close, in a semi-circle if possible. Show the cover or one picture and ask: What do you see? What will happen?

4 **Tell:** use voice, face and gestures. Pause before the exciting part. Repeat key lines and let children join in.

5 **After:** ask 3 questions (who, what happened, why), let pairs retell the story, then draw or write one sentence about it.

Read-aloud: the teacher as reading model

- Read a big book, textbook story or chart daily for 5-10 minutes, finger under the words so children connect sound to print.
- Read with expression. Stop at difficult words, explain with a picture, action or simple synonym - then reread the sentence.
- Ask prediction questions: What will happen next? This builds comprehension, not just decoding.

Picture talk (Classes 1-2)

Show one large picture. Children name everything they see, then make sentences: *The boy is carrying water.* Picture talk is the bridge from home language talk to school language reading and writing.

> **Common mistake:** Asking only "Did you like the story?" End with retelling and questions that check understanding, or the listening does not become learning.

SECTION 4

Play-based and activity-based learning

For a young child, play is not a break from learning. Play is how learning happens - language, number, rules, friendship and self-control all grow in play.

Three kinds of play in school

Kind	Example	What it teaches
Free play	Blocks, sand, make-believe corner	Creativity, social skills, language
Guided play	Shop game with price cards	Money, counting, polite language
Learning games	Word bingo, number race, flashcard pairs	Target words, sums, quick recall

Running a learning game well

- **One clear learning point.** If the game practises everything, it teaches nothing. Name the point: today, words for animals.
- **Show, do not only tell.** Play one round with a confident child while the class watches.
- **Every child plays.** Pairs and small groups, not one child at the board while 40 watch.
- **End with the learning.** Ask: What did we practise? Say the words or sums once more together.

Activity-based learning (Classes 2-5)

The child does something real with the concept: sorting leaves by shape in science, measuring the classroom in maths, making a family tree in social studies. The cycle is always the same: **Do - Talk - Record.** First the activity, then discussion of what happened, then drawing or writing it down. Skipping "record" is why activities are forgotten by the next day.

> **Common mistake:** Activity without a conclusion. Noise and movement feel busy, but learning lands in the last 5 minutes when you name what was learned.

SECTION 5

Questioning and classroom discussion

Questions are the teacher's steering wheel. They reveal what children understood, and they push thinking further than any lecture.

Three levels of questions

Level	Purpose	Examples
Remember	Recall facts from the lesson	What is this called? Who came first?
Understand	Explain in own words, compare	Why did he run away? How are these two different?
Think	Predict, judge, solve	What will happen if...? What would you do? How can we check?

Use all three levels in every lesson. Only "remember" questions produce children who can repeat but cannot think.

Technique that doubles learning

- **Wait time:** ask, then wait 3-5 seconds in silence. More children answer, and answers get longer.
- **No hands first:** let pairs discuss for 30 seconds, then take answers. Every child thinks, not only the fastest hand.
- **Spread the turns:** ask the back rows, the quiet children and the girls as deliberately as the front row.
- **Build on answers:** "Good - who can add more?" and "Why do you think so?" turn one answer into a discussion.
- **Wrong answers:** thank the attempt, find the correct part, and guide to the full answer. Never laugh, never allow laughing.

Discussion routine (5 minutes): Pose one question - pairs talk - 3 pairs share - teacher summarises the best points on the board. Use it at the start to revise yesterday, and at the end to close today's lesson.

SECTION 6

Demonstration and modelling: I do - We do - You do

Children cannot practise what they have never seen done well. Demonstration gives them a clear model; gradual release gives them independence step by step.

1. I DO

Teacher performs the skill, thinking aloud: "Watch how I join these letters... first I start on the line."

2. WE DO

Class does it with the teacher: one example together on the board, children on slates or in the air.

3. YOU DO

Children practise alone or in pairs. Teacher moves, watches, corrects and helps.

Rules of a good demonstration

- **Everyone must see.** Gather children close, hold material up, write large. Check the view from the back row yourself.
- **Slow and in steps.** Break the skill into 3-5 steps and name each step as you do it.
- **Show a mistake on purpose.** Do it wrong, let children spot the error, then do it right. Errors become memorable lessons.
- **Keep it short.** 5-8 minutes. Long demonstrations become lectures and attention dies.

Where modelling matters most

Handwriting: letter formation on the board, stroke by stroke. **Reading:** fluent read-aloud with expression. **Maths:** working a sum on the board, saying each step. **Science:** safe handling and fair testing. **Behaviour:** greeting, asking for help, and putting things away - model the behaviour you expect, every day.

> **Common mistake:** Jumping from "I do" straight to written homework. Without "We do", half the class practises the wrong method at home - and wrong practice is hard to undo.

SECTION 7

Pair work, group work and peer learning

In a class of 40, the teacher is one voice. In pairs, 20 conversations happen at once - and speaking is how language and ideas are practised.

Pair work: the simplest powerful method

- **Think-Pair-Share:** think alone (30 seconds), tell your partner, then share with the class. Use it for any question.
- **Reading partners:** partners take turns reading a paragraph aloud and helping each other with hard words.
- **Check partners:** after written work, partners compare answers and explain differences before the teacher checks.

Change partners regularly. Pair a stronger child with a weaker one for practice tasks, and pair equal levels for challenge tasks.

Group work that actually works (4-6 children)

1. **Give roles:** leader, reader, writer, reporter, timekeeper. Roles stop one child doing everything.
2. **Give one clear product:** a poster, a list, a solved set of sums, a short presentation - with a time limit.
3. **Move and listen:** visit each group, ask probing questions, note common errors for the closing discussion.
4. **Report and praise:** reporters present; class listens for one good point in each report.

Peer learning

A child who has just mastered a skill often explains it in words classmates understand. Use confident children as peer helpers for revision and in multigrade classes - while the teacher keeps responsibility for new teaching. Rotate helpers so helping stays an honour, not a burden.

> **Common mistake:** Group work without roles or a product. It becomes chatting. Structure first, freedom inside the structure.

SECTION 8

Teaching early reading and writing

Reading is not one skill. It is a staircase. Teach each step in order, and do not rush a child up a step they have not secured.

The reading staircase

Step	Skill	Classroom activity
1. Listen	Hearing sounds in words	Rhymes, songs, clapping syllables, first-sound games
2. Sounds	Letter sounds (phonics)	Flashcards, sound actions, sand or air writing
3. Blend	Joining sounds: c-a-t = cat	Blending games, word building with letter cards
4. Words	Reading whole words quickly	Word walls, matching games, repeated reading
5. Sentences	Reading with meaning	Shared reading, sentence building, picture sentences
6. Stories	Understanding and enjoying text	Read-aloud, questions, retelling, class library

Daily reading routine (15-20 minutes)

- **Shared reading:** whole class reads a chart or big book together, teacher leading.
- **Guided practice:** groups read levelled text; teacher listens to one group closely each day.
- **Independent reading:** every child with a book at their own level, even for 5 quiet minutes.

Early writing

Writing grows the same way: drawing and scribble, tracing and copying, words, sentences, then short paragraphs. Model sentence writing on the board daily ("I do"), build one sentence together ("We do"), then let children write their own ("You do"). Praise content first, then correct one spelling or punctuation point at a time.

SECTION 9

Teaching early maths with concrete materials

Most maths failure in primary school is one thing: symbols taught before understanding. The cure is the CPA sequence - Concrete, Pictorial, Abstract.

CONCRETE

Real objects: stones, sticks, bottle caps, beans. Children count, group, add and take away with their hands.

PICTORIAL

Drawings of the objects: circles, tallies, number lines, bar pictures on slates and in copies.

ABSTRACT

Symbols only: 7 + 5 = 12. Reached last, and understood because the child has already done it by hand.

Example: teaching place value (Class 3)

1 **Concrete:** bundles of 10 sticks and single sticks. 34 is 3 bundles and 4 singles - children make several numbers.

2 **Pictorial:** draw bundles and singles in the copy; write the number beside the drawing.

3 **Abstract:** write and read 34, 47, 58 without materials - then return to bundles whenever a child is stuck.

Five habits of strong primary maths teaching

- **Talk maths:** children explain how they solved it. Different methods are celebrated, not corrected away.
- **Daily mental maths:** 5 minutes of quick oral sums at the start builds number fluency.
- **Word problems from real life:** market prices, bus fares, cricket scores, sharing sweets equally.
- **Tables through rhythm:** chant, clap and game the times tables; understanding first (groups of), memorising second.
- **Errors are information:** a wrong answer shows the exact step to reteach. Keep a note of common errors.

SECTION 10

Multigrade, large classes, differentiation and inclusion

In many Khyber Pakhtunkhwa primary schools one teacher teaches two classes, or 50 children at different levels, in one room. The methods on this page are made for that reality.

Multigrade teaching: one theme, different tasks

- **Teach together, practise apart:** start both classes with the same story, picture or demonstration, then give each class its own practice task.
- **Stagger your attention:** teach Class A directly for 10 minutes while Class B does a prepared task; then swap. Prepared task cards make this possible.
- **Use peer helpers:** trained older children lead reading practice and games for younger groups.
- **Keep routines identical:** same signals, same places for materials, same start and finish - routine saves the minutes you cannot spare.

Differentiation: same lesson, three levels of task

Level	Task design	Example (writing)
Support	Sentence starters, word bank, fewer items	Complete: "The goat is ___."
Core	The standard objective for the class	Write 3 sentences about the goat.
Challenge	Extension: explain, compare, create	Write a short paragraph: goat vs cow.

Every child attempts the core idea; nobody is labelled. Move children between levels task by task, as they grow.

Inclusion in ordinary lessons

Seat children with weak sight or hearing near the front. Give instructions in two ways - spoken and written or drawn. Allow extra time and oral answers where writing is the barrier, not the learning. A child who is behind needs smaller steps and more praise, not fewer opportunities.

SECTION 11

Checking understanding, low-cost aids and board work

Do not wait for the monthly test to discover that half the class did not understand. Check during the lesson, while reteaching is still cheap.

Five quick checks (under 2 minutes each)

- **Show-me boards:** all children write the answer on a slate or card and hold it up. You see 40 answers in 10 seconds.
- **Exit question:** one question on the day's objective, answered on a slip before leaving.
- **Thumbs:** up = I understand, sideways = partly, down = I need help. Use it to form help groups.
- **Teach-back:** a child explains the idea to a partner. If they cannot explain it, they have not learned it yet.
- **Sample copies:** check 5 copies during practice - top, middle and struggling learners - not only the first bench.

Low-cost teaching aids that earn their place

Flashcards for sounds and words. A number line painted or taped along the wall. Bottle-cap counters in a tin for every pair. A word wall that grows with the term. Charts made by the children themselves - a chart a child helped make is remembered twice as well. Keep aids where children can reach and return them without asking.

Board work

- Divide the board: left for the date and objective, centre for teaching, right for new words. Same layout every day.
- Write large, in lines, and step aside so the whole class can see. Read aloud what you write.
- Leave the summary on the board until the end of the lesson - it is the lesson's memory.

The feedback rule: Mark for one thing at a time, write one clear correction, and let the child redo that part. A page covered in red teaches only that writing is painful.

SECTION 12 - WORKED EXAMPLE

A complete model lesson: Class 4 English (35 minutes)

Objective: By the end of the lesson, children will use *can / cannot* in spoken and written sentences about abilities. **Materials:** board, picture cards of actions (swim, fly, climb, sing), exercise books.

Time	Stage and method	What happens
0-4 min	**Starter** Questioning	Teacher mimes swimming. "What am I doing? Can a fish swim? Can a fish fly?" Pairs discuss, then answer.
4-10 min	**Model** Demonstration	Picture cards on the board. Teacher models: "A bird can fly. A bird cannot swim." Children repeat chorally and in rows.
10-16 min	**Guided practice** We do	Together the class builds 3 sentences with new cards. Teacher writes them, children read them back.
16-26 min	**Pair practice** Pair work / game	In pairs, children ask and answer with cards: "Can a cat climb?" - "Yes, a cat can climb." Teacher monitors and notes errors.
26-32 min	**Written work** Differentiation	Support: complete 3 sentences. Core: write 4 own sentences. Challenge: write about a classmate's abilities.
32-35 min	**Close** Exit question	Each child tells a partner one true "I can..." sentence. Teacher collects 5 books to check tonight.

Why this lesson works: It moves I do - We do - You do, every child speaks in pairs, the written task is tiered, and understanding is checked before the lesson ends - not discovered next week.

Adapting the pattern

The same skeleton fits any subject: starter question, clear model, guided practice, independent or pair practice, tiered written work, closing check. Change only the content and materials.

KEEP AND USE

Daily checklist, common mistakes and revision

Before and during every lesson - tick honestly

- My objective is one clear sentence.
- I modelled the new learning (I do).
- We practised together (We do).
- Children practised themselves (You do).
- Every child spoke or wrote, not only volunteers.
- I used a concrete object, picture or story.
- I asked remember, understand and think questions.
- I waited after questions instead of answering myself.
- I checked understanding before the lesson ended.
- I know who needs reteaching tomorrow.

Five common mistakes - and the fix

Mistake	Fix
Teacher talks for the whole lesson	Model for 5-8 minutes, then hand the work to the children
Copying from the board as the main activity	Copying is recording, not learning - add talk, practice and questions
Only the front row answers	Pair discussion first, then choose who answers
Abstract rules before concrete examples	Concrete - Picture - Abstract, in that order
Testing without checking during the lesson	Show-me boards and exit questions in every lesson

Words to know for induction revision

Pedagogy: the science and art of teaching. **Child-centred:** learning designed around the child's activity and needs. **Scaffolding:** support that is removed gradually as the child gains skill. **Formative assessment:** checking during learning in order to improve it. **Differentiation:** adjusting tasks so all levels can succeed. **Multigrade:** one teacher teaching two or more classes together. **CPA:** Concrete - Pictorial - Abstract sequence in maths. **Bloom's levels:** question levels from remembering to creating.

Remember: Children do not learn from the method you planned. They learn from the activity they actually did. Plan the child's activity first - and the method will choose itself.

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